50TH ANNIVERSARY

A DEADLY DECADE
1975-1985

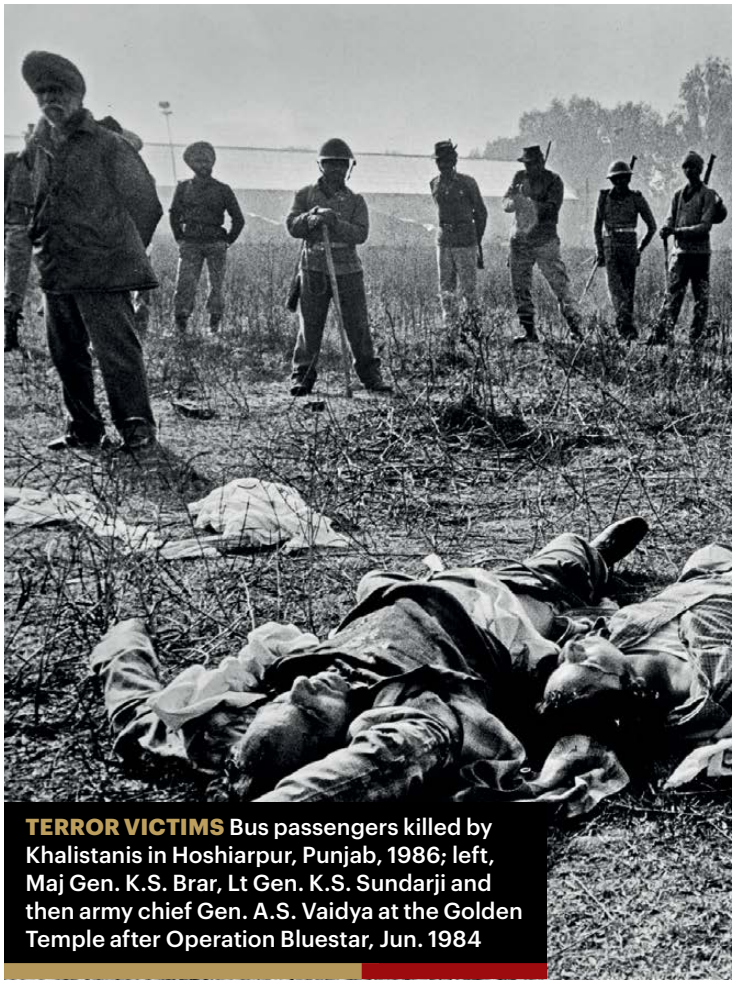
In 1982, he joined the Akalis' Dharam Yudh Morcha protests for Sikh demands, but soon chose a radical path and moved into the Golden Temple complex in Amritsar. Here he held court as grand inquisitor and directed a bloodbath against Hindus and moderate Sikhs. In 1984, Prime Minister Indira Gandhi finally moved against his temple fortress in Operation Bluestar (June 1-6). Bhindranwale perished in the army action, but Bluestar was a miscalculation that took lives of 332 soldiers and hundreds of militants and innocents. It also caused a dangerous cleft in India's polity. The episode proved that religion for political ends doesn't pay and that secessionist demagoguery cannot be indulged. ■

INDIA TODAY ARCHIVES

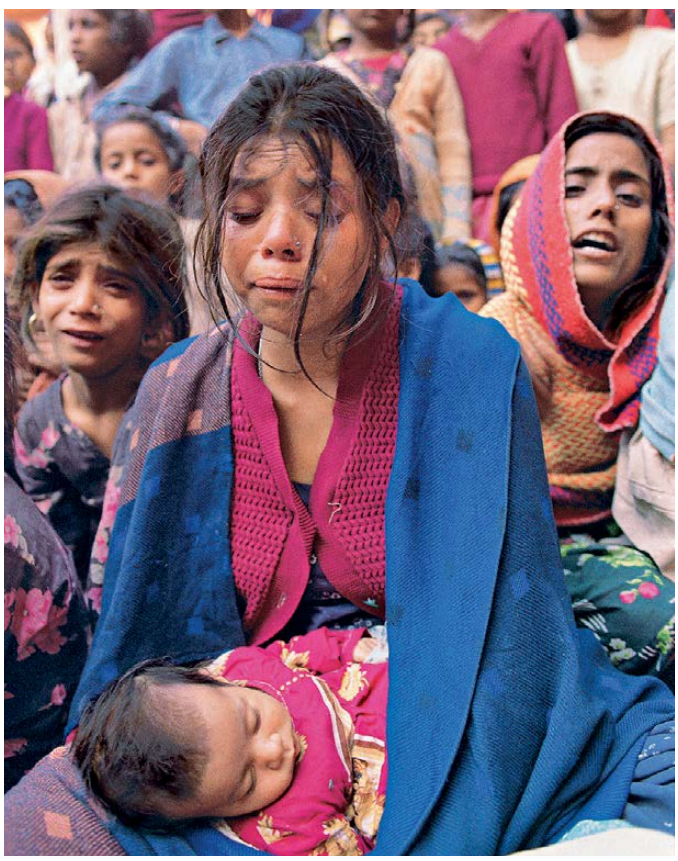


Operation Bluestar: INDIA TODAY, *Jun. 30, 1984*

"On the night of June 5, there was a bloody close quarter battle before the serais as defenders' machine-guns fired from all directions and the jawans had to fight pitched battles to clear each emplacement.... This evening, the marble turned into a gory mosaic of red and olive green as jawans, caught on a flat surface with no cover fell to the massive barrage of machine-gun fire.... Towards the evening of June 6, a decision had been taken to overcome the Akal Takht defences by using artillery fire.... Sometime in the course of the night Bhindranwale, along with Shahbeg Singh and Amrik Singh decided to fight the last battle from the Akal Takht basement. When jawans overpowered a machine-gun nest by throwing grenades, one of the shell splinters hit Bhindranwale in the face. As he tried to take cover elsewhere, he was caught in bursts of Sten-gun fire."



TERROR VICTIMS Bus passengers killed by Khalistanis in Hoshiarpur, Punjab, 1986; left, Maj Gen. K.S. Brar, Lt Gen. K.S. Sundarji and then army chief Gen. A.S. Vaidya at the Golden Temple after Operation Bluestar, Jun. 1984



RAGHU RAI